

Piano Lessons for Absolute Beginners

Lesson 5: Introduction to Chords: C Major Chord

Introduction to Chords: C Major Chord - Study Notes

Key Concepts

- **Chord:** A group of two or more notes played simultaneously.
- **C Major Chord:** A specific chord consisting of the notes C, E, and G.
- **Voicing:** The relative loudness or emphasis of each note within a chord, and how it affects the overall sound.
- **Simultaneous Pressing:** Playing multiple notes at the exact same time.
- **Clarity:** Ensuring each note within the chord is audible and distinct.

Summary

This lesson introduces the fundamental concept of chords, which are groups of notes played together to create a richer and fuller sound than a single note. We begin with the C Major chord, a foundational chord in music. The C Major chord is built from the notes C, E, and G. To play it, you press these three keys simultaneously using your right hand: finger 1 on C, finger 3 on E, and finger 5 on G.

Beyond simply playing the chord, this lesson also touches on the idea of "voicing." Voicing refers to how the loudness of each note within the chord impacts the overall sound. Experimenting with slightly different pressure on each key will demonstrate how you can subtly alter the chord's character. Consistent practice focusing on clarity – ensuring all three notes ring out clearly – is key to mastering this first chord.

Important Points

- **Chord Definition:** A chord is more than just two notes; it's a collection of notes played together.
- **C Major Chord Notes:** The C Major chord is always composed of the notes C, E, and G.

Memorize this!

- **Finger Placement (Right Hand):**

* 1 = C

* 3 = E

* 5 = G

- **Simultaneous Action:** All three keys must be pressed down *at the same time* to form the chord.

- **Voicing Experimentation:** Try pressing one key slightly harder than the others. Notice the change in the chord's sound. This is voicing.

- **Clarity is Key:** Make sure each note (C, E, and G) is clearly audible. Adjust your finger pressure if needed.

Examples

Example 1: Simple Repetition

Play the C Major chord repeatedly. Focus on pressing all three keys down at the same time and listening

for a clear, full sound. Count "1-2-3" as you play each chord. This helps build muscle memory and coordination.

****Example 2: Voicing Variation****

Play the C Major chord. Now, press the C key slightly harder than the E and G keys. Listen to how the chord sounds different. Then, press the E key harder. Finally, press the G key harder. Notice how each change in pressure alters the chord's character. This demonstrates how voicing affects the sound.

Quick Review

1. What three notes make up the C Major chord?
2. What finger number do you use to play the note E in the C Major chord (using the right hand)?
3. What does "voicing" refer to in the context of chords?
4. Why is it important to ensure all three notes of the C Major chord sound clearly?
5. True or False: A chord must have at least two notes to be considered a chord.

Further Reading

- ****Major Scales:**** Understanding the C Major scale (C-D-E-F-G-A-B-C) will help you understand the relationship between the C Major chord and the key of C Major.
- ****Other Major Chords:**** Explore other major chords like G Major (G-B-D) and F Major (F-A-C).
- ****Chord Progressions:**** Learn how chords are combined to create musical progressions. Start with simple progressions like C-G-Am-F.
- ****Inversions:**** Investigate chord inversions, which change the order of the notes within a chord while maintaining the same fundamental sound.
- ****Minor Chords:**** Explore the differences between major and minor chords.

